to do with its irrational and inconsistent usage of the Schrödinger equation. Even from a positivist perspective, the measurement problem appeared grave to Everett. When does collapse happen? Why does the Schrödinger equation apply at some times but not others? Frank was clearly troubled by this too, as he wrote in his reply to Everett: “I have always disliked the traditional treatment of ‘measurement’ in Quantum Theory according to which it seems as if measurement would be a type of fact which is essentially different from all other physical facts.” Rather than saving realism, as Bohm and Shimony and others wanted to do, Everett had simply wanted to fix this hole in physics and to have a good time while doing it. “He wanted a quick short thesis project and punking the measurement problem made him laugh,” Everett’s biographer, Peter Byrne, said.

Everett had kept up with developments in the foundations of physics over the years, but he had never published anything on the subject after finishing his PhD thesis. He had certainly never spoken about it publicly—he hated public speaking—and he rarely even spoke about it with friends or colleagues. When Don Reisler, a physicist with a PhD in quantum foundations, applied to work at Everett’s company, Everett shyly asked if he was aware of the relative-state interpretation. Reisler immediately thought, “Oh my God, you are *that* Everett, the crazy one.” He said he had heard of the theory. They became great friends, but they never spoke of quantum physics again. And even as awareness of Everett’s ideas spread, they were still often met with ridicule and withering contempt. Writing about “cognitive repression in contemporary physics,” the physicist-turned-philosopher Evelyn Fox Keller said that the many-worlds interpretation “demonstrates remarkable ingenuity,” in the solutions it provides for the measurement problem and other quantum paradoxes. But, she concluded, “a price has been paid—namely the price of seriousness.” More criticism of Everett was yet to come, and not from some unknown quarter but from an old ally.

Shortly after Everett’s Austin seminar, Wheeler received a draft of a paper criticizing the many-worlds interpretation, which the paper termed the